

Argentina

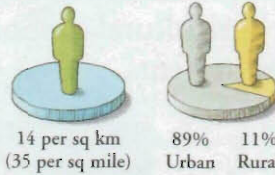
 After Brazil, Argentina is the second largest country in South America. It is separated from Uruguay by the Río de la Plata estuary, on which its capital, Buenos Aires, stands. Argentina is one of the wealthiest countries in South America, with fertile soils, a wealth of mineral resources, and a skilled work-force. However, years of political instability have left huge overseas debts, which caused the economy to collapse at the end of 2001.



Couple dancing the tango

People

More than 89 per cent of Argentina's people live in towns and cities and most enjoy a high standard of living. However, city slums, or *orillas*, illustrate the sharp contrast between the country's rich and poor. It was in the slums that the tango, the traditional dance of Buenos Aires, originated, in the late 1800s. Many tangos contain lyrics that express the frustrations of the immigrants who came from Spain, Italy, Austria, France, Germany, and Britain. The tango is now famous worldwide.

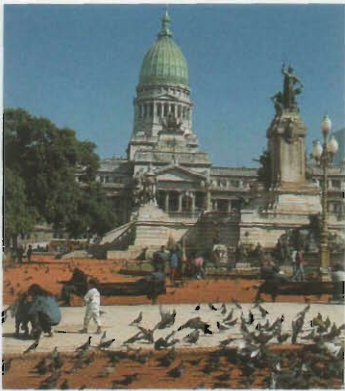


Clarín is Argentina's best-selling newspaper.



ARGENTINA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Buenos Aires
AREA	2,736,690 sq km (1,056,636 sq miles)
POPULATION	37,000,000
MAIN LANGUAGE	Spanish
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Argentinian peso
LIFE EXPECTANCY	73 years
PEOPLE PER DOCTOR	370
GOVERNMENT	Multi-party democracy
ADULT LITERACY	97%



Buenos Aires

Situated on the South Atlantic coast, Argentina's capital has been an important trade port since it was founded by the Spanish in 1536. Buenos Aires is a wealthy, sophisticated city, with expensive shops, fine avenues, and modern buildings, as well as a spectacular old cathedral. The city is the centre of government, industry, and culture. Almost 40 per cent of Argentinians, numbering about 14,000,000, live in the metropolitan capital, referring to it as "Baires".

Government buildings

Food

High-quality beef, which is produced throughout Argentina, is used as a base for many local dishes, such as *empanadas*, or savoury mince pastries. Every restaurant has a barbeque grill, or *parillada*. As a cheaper alternative to meat, many people eat small potato dumplings called *noquis*, which were introduced by Italian immigrants.



Noquis



Farming

Agriculture accounts for about 60 per cent of Argentina's export earnings. The country is a major producer of wheat, barley, and maize, which flourish on the pampas, and is the world's third largest producer of soya beans. Fruit, especially oranges, grows well in the warm climate, and grapes are produced for wine-making.

Harvesting barley on the fertile pampas

Bolas rope used to slow down cattle

Gauchos

Tough, independent gauchos, or cowhands, have roamed the pampas on horseback for more than 300 years, tending cattle and horses. Modern gauchos work mainly on huge *estancias*, or ranches, owned by wealthy landlords, where they rear animals and mend fences. Gauchos are experts in handling herds and are the national heroes of Argentina.



Woollen poncho, or cloak, for warmth at night

Strong boots have heels to fit into stirrups.

Newspapers

More than 180 daily newspapers are published every day in Argentina. Most are in Spanish, but English, French, and German papers are widely available. In the past, dictatorships have imposed censorship on the media, and today's government withdraws advertising from those who do not support its policies.



Schooling

Literacy is high in Argentina, and free-state primary and secondary education is provided. Schooling is compulsory for all children between the ages of six and 14, and more than one-third of all students go on to one of Argentina's 45 universities. Buenos Aires has the largest university in South America, with 140,000 students.

These women work in a fish-packing plant and must wear hats for hygiene.



The Falkland Islands lie 480 km (300 miles) east of Argentina.

Industry

About 30 per cent of the labour force works in industry. Textiles, food production, and chemical products dominate business. The country is self-sufficient in oil and gas, and rich in minerals.

Falkland Islands

Britain and Argentina have fought over ownership of the Falkland Islands, or *Islas Malvinas*, since the British claimed the islands from the Spanish in 1833. In 1982, an Argentine invasion of the islands was overthrown, and the British continue to hold them.

